

SKOAR!

DEAD SPACE 3

Visceral combat

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Dead Space 3 is an undeniably superlative game. The combat is rock-solid, fast and frenzied and the amount of detail in the environment is just excellent. The game, regardless of what we might say or complain about in the course of this review, is a must-play for fans and gamers alike.

The game picks up a few years after the last game ended, with Isaac Clarke in denial and in hiding from the fanatical Unitologists as he tries to forget his past. Plans of galactic domination, absurd love triangles, ultimate weapons and a forgotten alien race barely manage to form an interesting story. Thankfully though, almost everything else is just so much more fun that you don't even notice it.

The environments in Dead Space 3 are a little hard to describe, they are simultaneously massive and tiny. In the course of your journey you get glimpses of the sheer scale of the game, but you actually end up fighting in locations that are surprisingly small. Almost all the combat revolves around entering one miniature set-piece after another, clearing out rooms in sequence, trying to anticipate how your next action will trigger the next wave of enemies.

The pacing of the earlier games is gone, the weapons in Dead Space 1 and 2 were hard-hitting, but also required more precision and skill to manage. Health packs and ammo were scarce and every fight was a true battle. Dead Space 3 moves away from all of that. You get dozens of med-packs, hundreds of rounds of ammo and don't even get me started on the stasis modules. You run through ammo and enemies

at an alarming rate; rate of fire and magazine size take precedence over precision and the tension of the game's survival-horror roots are replaced by an adrenaline-fuelled, action frenzy.

There isn't anything wrong with that much action, in such a well-built game, the action is bucket-loads of fun; it's just that as a fan of the series, we were a little disappointed at the lack of "horror" or tension when we were playing the game. It almost feels like a transition from Counter-Strike to Call of Duty; which isn't bad by any means, it just feels a little jarring if you've played the game's predecessors.

The overall audio of the game matches, and maybe even surpasses the visual beauty of the game. The soundtrack manages to introduce a semblance of tension in scenes that require it but the sound effects, the moaning and groaning of the necromorphs, the weapon effects, etc. are simply superb.

Another aspect that is implemented very well is the weapon crafting. Unlike the first couple of games, you now have various resources to collect and you can use these resources to craft weapons. The crafting feels a little awkward at first as you've no clue what to do, but as you get the hang of it, you will craft some truly personal weapons that are well-adapted to your play style. The one thing that takes away from this experience is the system of "micro"-transactions that have been introduced, a trend that is getting more and more prevalent in EA titles off-late. They feel more like some marketing chap's idea to extract some more money from gamers; as a tasteless feature that had to be implemented however, Visceral Games have done an excellent job in making sure it's well integrated into the interface. The new game+ and co-op modes that have been

included are excellent and serve their purpose well. Both serve to enhance Dead Space 3's strong points by focusing on the action rather than the lack-lustre, but somehow fulfilling, story. Co-op mode opens up previously hidden or inaccessible areas and you even get a glimpse of some of the backstory that was missing from the main storyline. We would strongly suggest that you first finish playing the game in single-player before venturing into co-op. *

Verdict

There is just so much more to talk about when it comes to this game and what we have written so far barely scratches the surface of what Dead Space 3 really is, but then again, too much talk can ruin it. The game is excellent, play it. We can safely say that this is, without a shadow of a doubt, one of the best games that you will play this year and, despite its minor flaws, well worth the money and the time you will spend on this game.

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- » **Developer:** Visceral Games
- » **Publisher:** Electronic Arts
- » **Platform:** Xbox 360, PS3, PC
- » **Price:** ₹1799 (PC)

